

The Define Phase

Understand the problem completely before you ever try to fix it.

The Goal

Define is the first step of DMAIC, and its only job is to fully understand the problem before touching it. Imagine a pizza shop where customers complain their pizzas arrive cold. It is tempting to just yell at the drivers to drive faster, but Six Sigma requires patience and discipline first.

The Project Charter

Instead of rushing, you create a Project Charter, a one-page document that officially defines what is broken, why it matters to the business, and what success looks like. You define exactly what cold means to the customer, identify which neighborhoods are complaining, and set a measurable goal like cutting cold deliveries by fifty percent.

Why It Matters

By the end of this phase your whole team agrees on exactly which problem you are solving. You put a strict boundary around the project so nobody wastes time, money, or energy chasing the wrong issue.

Remember this

Define the problem clearly first, because you cannot fix what you have not pinned down.